Learning-Aware Lyapunov Resource Control for Correlated Multi-Agent Markov Learning

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***Abstract*—Parallel policy evaluation estimates a common policy's value from multiple Markov trajectories. Shared disturbances can make additional actors increase communication without providing proportional information. We develop a finite-budget controller that jointly selects participation, sample spacing, and step size for affine delayed temporal-difference learning. A discrete Lyapunov bound converts cross-agent second moments, temporal mixing, and update staleness into a terminal-risk score over the affordable learning horizon. For unknown dependence, a learning-value gate compares the certified benefit of identification with its message, transition, delay, and decision-error costs. The analysis gives delayed convergence and critic-tracking bounds, a stopped adaptive information lower bound, and an explicit selection-dependence correction linking same-stream probes to downstream learning risk. On a separated Gaussian Markov class, a budget-threshold sandwich links identification feasibility to learning value. Controlled simulations reduce two finite-budget risks by 35.2 and 9.8 percent relative to information-only probing. On 64 held-out seeds, joint control reduces parameter-error and discounted-return-estimation curve integrals by 9.9 and 11.3 percent against a development-selected fixed baseline. A separate 196,608-trajectory validation executes the actual-risk gate on known Gaussian models; all high-regime aggregate intervals favor probing over the all-agent fallback, but one low-regime aggregate is adverse. The corrected and uncorrected gates select identical actions on this grid, leaving the correction's incremental empirical benefit unresolved.**

***Index Terms*—Multi-agent learning, Markov data, temporal-difference learning, adaptive sensing, Lyapunov methods.**

I. Introduction

Policy evaluation estimates the discounted return of a fixed policy, supplying the critics and advantages used by actor–critic systems. We study parallel actors executing a common target policy on Markov environment copies and sending temporal-difference observations to a value-learning server. The server chooses participation q, physical sample spacing b, and step size η under finite message and environment-clock budgets.

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Parallel samples need not provide parallel information: actors can share simulator randomness or exogenous disturbances while preserving their marginal transition laws. At correlation $\rho > 0$, equicorrelated Gaussian observations provide effective participation $q/[1 + (q - 1)\rho] \leq 1/\rho$, while messages grow with q. Larger spacing suppresses Markov bias but consumes transitions; larger steps accelerate contraction but raise noise and stale-update risk. The design must price these effects against the affordable learning horizon and dependence-identification cost.

Temporal-difference and stochastic-approximation theory [1]–[4] provides finite-time analyses under Markov sampling [5]–[7], concentration bounds [8], and Lyapunov-based adaptive learning rates [9]. Participation and spacing also determine the observation stream.

Distributed/federated learning studies consensus, parallelism, coverage, and sample–communication tradeoffs [10]–[15]. Clustered clients, adaptive batches, and antithetic sampling regulate variance [16]–[18]; feedback controls participation [19], while convergence-bound-driven Lyapunov control selects clients and powers [20]. We ask how covariance and spacing change error per update and the number of affordable updates.

Asynchronous optimization analyzes stale computation [21]–[23]; delay-adaptive stochastic approximation [24], [25] and stochastic delay differential equations (SDDEs) support convergence and worker-activation design [26]. Here delay, cross-agent covariance, and paid spacing jointly determine terminal risk. DASA [25] permits unbounded delays and obtains an average-delay rate, but its cross-agent independence assumption removes the common-source covariance considered here. Lyapunov client/power scheduling [20] minimizes a convergence/time surrogate under average power constraints; SDDE worker activation [26] optimizes a delay-dependent convergence approximation. Our distinction is a paid identification decision evaluated through the remaining learner's terminal risk, including its dependence on the same continuing stream.

Sequential design and identification supply change-of-measure/allocation tools [27]–[33], with conservative bandits constraining baseline-relative reward [34]. We value identification through its effect on the re-

maining learner's risk. Covariance-adaptive identification [32] minimizes joint-query complexity for independent rounds, rather than the downstream learner's risk after paying those queries. Parameter-free TD [35] addresses unknown step-size constants, and adaptive Markov SA [36] controls all-future trajectory excursions under kernel regularity. Neither objective replaces the finite-budget risk comparison studied here; our certificate construction for a known finite model is given in the supplementary material. An action-dependent Lyapunov certificate combines the error per update with the number of affordable updates. The resulting terminal-risk score supports scalar step searches within each discrete (q, b) pair. For unknown dependence, a likelihood probe is admitted when its certified downstream improvement exceeds message, transition, delay, and decision-error costs while respecting a low-instance risk allowance.

The main contributions are as follows.

- **Finite-Budget Lyapunov Resource Design:** A terminal-risk score couples participation, physical Markov spacing, and step size to the number of affordable updates under dual budgets. The Gaussian resource geometry has an exact correlation-limited speedup ceiling.
- **Learning and Certificate Guarantees:** An affine delayed Markov bound supplies the score and a moving-policy critic-tracking guarantee under uniform-history conditions. Predictable moment/mixing upper bounds control calibration-induced risk and selection error.
- **Information-to-Learning Risk Transfer:** A stopped adaptive information identity and controlled-belief occupation program lower-bound identification cost; a learning-value gate yields finite-budget guarantees and a threshold sandwich on a separated Gaussian class. An explicit same-stream correction transfers identification error into actual risk for both a running mean and an averaged delayed affine learner, closing the probe–learning dependence in the controlled experiments.
- **Resource-Matched Learning Evidence:** Controlled studies quantify the estimation gains from learning-aware probing and finite-horizon control using risk and area under the curve (AUC). Held-out multi-agent proximal policy optimization (MAPPO) studies improve team-return AUC against the strongest single fixed-participation comparators on particles and locomotion, with all 32 controller runs selecting dependence-matched participation. A separate direct validation tests the executed actual-risk gate with new seeds and retains its adverse comparisons and identical no-carryover ablation.

II. Model and Finite-Budget Objective

A. Fixed-policy evaluation with multiple actors

Let $(\mathcal{S}, \mathcal{U}, P, r, \gamma)$ be a discounted Markov decision process and let $\pi_{\mathrm{tar}}(u \mid s)$ be a fixed target policy. Under π_{tar}, the state–action process is a Markov reward process with transition kernel P_π and stationary distribution π. For a feature vector $\phi(s) \in \mathbb{R}^d$, the linear value approximation is $V_w(s) = \phi(s)^\top w$. Its projected Bellman fixed point $w^\star$ solves

$$Aw^\star = c, \quad A = \mathbb{E}_\pi[\phi_t(\phi_t - \gamma\phi_{t+1})^\top], \quad c = \mathbb{E}_\pi[r_t\phi_t]. \tag{1}$$

Let S_k be the start of retained transition k and $X_{i,k} = (s_{i,S_k}, r_{i,S_k}, s_{i,S_k+1})$. The server chooses $q_k \in \{1, \dots, Q\}$ actors and start-to-start spacing $b_k \in \mathbb{N}$. For temporal-difference data, P_q is a Markov augmentation containing the joint transition tuples, not the raw state kernel; retained starts are separated by b_k kernel steps. Its invariant law π_q satisfies the total-variation (TV) bound

$$\sup_z \left\| P_q^b(z, \cdot) - \pi_q \right\|_{\mathrm{TV}} \le C_q r_q^b, \quad 0 < r_q < 1. \tag{2}$$

Every actor has the target-policy marginal law; cross-agent dependence enters the aggregate stationary moments.

For the identification layer, a Gaussian common-factor subclass makes the dependence parameter explicit. Under instance $j \in \{0, 1\}$,

$$\begin{aligned} C_{S_k} &= \lambda^{b_k} C_{S_{k-1}} + \sqrt{1 - \lambda^{2b_k}}\, \xi_{j,k}, \\ X_{i,k} &= C_{S_k} + \epsilon_{i,k}, \end{aligned} \tag{3}$$

where $\xi_{j,k} \sim \mathcal{N}(0, \theta_j)$, $\epsilon_{i,k} \sim \mathcal{N}(0, 1)$, and all private innovations are independent. The common process is initialized with $C_{S_0} \sim \mathcal{N}(0, \theta_j)$, so fixed-clock probes are stationary. Under adaptive sampling, the conditional predictive law determines the information in each observation. The corresponding same-time correlation is $\rho_j = \theta_j/(1 + \theta_j)$. Within each instance, every actor has the same marginal law; changing θ_j changes both marginal variance and cross-agent correlation. This Gaussian subclass is used for the information boundary; the convergence theorem applies to bounded affine temporal-difference observations satisfying Assumption 1.

B. Affine delayed temporal-difference recursion

Let $w^\star \in \mathbb{R}^d$ be the projected temporal-difference fixed point and $e_k = w_k - w^\star$. For action $a = (q, b, \eta)$ and delays $0 \le \tau_i \le D$, the retained recursion is

$$e_{k+1} = e_k - \frac{\eta}{q} \sum_{i=1}^{q} \left(H_{i,k} e_{k-\tau_i} - \xi_{i,k} \right). \tag{4}$$

The rank-one matrix $H_{i,k}$ is the sample temporal-difference Jacobian and $\xi_{i,k}$ is the affine innovation at

$w^\star$. For temporal-difference (TD) learning with zero trace, TD(0), these quantities are

$$H_{i,k} = \phi_{i,k}(\phi_{i,k} - \gamma\phi'_{i,k})^\top, \quad \xi_{i,k} = \phi_{i,k}\delta_i(w^\star), \quad (5)$$

where $\delta_i(w) = r_{i,k} + \gamma\phi'_{i,k}{}^\top w - \phi_{i,k}^\top w$. The first tuple must satisfy the same conditional mixing bound, or be initialized independently from stationarity.

Assumption 1 (Certified action domain)**.** *The public sets $\mathcal{Q} \subseteq \{1, \dots, Q\}$ and $\mathcal{B} \subset \mathbb{N}$ are finite, while the step interval $[\eta_{\min}, \eta_{\max}]$ is compact. For each $a = (q, b, \eta)$ in their product: (a) $\|H_{i,k}\| \le L$ and $\|\xi_{i,k}\| \le G$ almost surely; (b) $\mathbb{E}_{\pi_q}\xi_{i,k} = 0$, and the common mean $A = \mathbb{E}_{\pi_q}H_{i,k}$ has symmetric part at least μI; (c) the delay profile is deterministic, satisfies $0 \le \tau_i \le D$, and is known when scoring; and (d) predictable upper bounds cover the stationary aggregate moments and the mixing law uniformly conditional on pre-observation history. Initialize $w_s = w_0$ for all $s \le 0$; increments before the first update are zero.*

Write $\mathcal{A} = \mathcal{Q} \times \mathcal{B} \times [\eta_{\min}, \eta_{\max}]$; integer actor counts and clocks are enumerated, with a continuous scalar step search.

C. Dual budgets and terminal risk

Each scheduled block pays $h + q$ message units and b parallel-clock units, including unused padding within the block. Let $u \ge 0$ count terminal scheduled updates excluded from the reported learner and let $\ell \ge 0$ be a separately declared physical startup/drain charge. The recursion's state-lag bound D is separate from these terminal charges; any equality is part of the declared protocol. A feasible trajectory therefore satisfies

$$\sum_k (h + q_k) \le B_{\mathrm{msg}}, \quad \sum_k b_k + \ell\mathbf{1}\{K > 0\} \le B_{\mathrm{env}}. \quad (6)$$

For a stationary action, all scheduled blocks are paid, and the usable horizon is

$$N_a(B) = \left[\min\left\{\left\lfloor\frac{B_{\mathrm{msg}}}{h+q}\right\rfloor, \left\lfloor\frac{B_{\mathrm{env}} - \ell}{b}\right\rfloor\right\} - u\right]_+. \quad (7)$$

The controller minimizes a finite-time certificate $\overline{R}_j(a; B, D)$ satisfying $\mathbb{E}_j\|e_{N_a}\|^2 \le \overline{R}_j(a; B, D)$. This parameter mean-square risk controls the value-estimation risk of $J_\nu(w) = \mathbb{E}_{s\sim\nu}V_w(s)$, as quantified by Corollary 1.

The Gaussian running-mean learner used in the mechanism study starts from a unit pseudo-observation. For $r = \lambda^b$, its exact risk is

$$R_j^{\mathrm{mean}}(a, N) = \frac{1 + N/q}{(N+1)^2} + \frac{\theta_j\left[N + 2\sum_{s=1}^{N-1}(N-s)r^s\right]}{(N+1)^2}. \quad (8)$$

Eq. (8) exposes opposing effects: larger q reduces private noise but can reduce N, while spacing controls r at a transition cost.

III. Correlation and Resource Geometry

A. A sharp spatial speedup ceiling

The statistical role of participation is exact in a Gaussian location subclass. Let $Y_{i,t} = \vartheta + C_t + \epsilon_{i,t}$ with common variance σ_c^2, private variance σ_e^2, and independent rounds. For a fixed participation q, the minimax squared-error risk after T rounds is

$$R_q(T) = \frac{1}{T}\left(\sigma_c^2 + \frac{\sigma_e^2}{q}\right). \quad (9)$$

Writing $\rho = \sigma_c^2/(\sigma_c^2 + \sigma_e^2)$ gives the speedup relative to one actor,

$$S(q, \rho) = \frac{R_1(T)}{R_q(T)} = \frac{q}{1 + (q-1)\rho} \le \min\{q, \rho^{-1}\}. \quad (10)$$

Thus information saturates at positive correlation while messages grow with q.

Proposition 1 (Participation phase under a message budget)**.** *Suppose the environment budget does not bind, $h > 0$, $0 < \rho < 1$, and a message budget B_{msg} is used with fixed q. Ignoring integer rounding, the minimax risk is proportional to*

$$F(q; \rho, h) = (h + q)\left(\rho + \frac{1-\rho}{q}\right). \quad (11)$$

Its continuous minimizer is

$$q^\star_{\mathrm{cont}} = \sqrt{\frac{h(1-\rho)}{\rho}}, \quad (12)$$

clipped to $[1, Q]$, and an integer optimum is one of its two neighboring feasible participation levels.

Differentiating F gives $\partial_q F = \rho - h(1-\rho)/q^2$, proving Proposition 1. Fixed overhead favors larger batches; common randomness favors smaller participation.

B. Temporal spacing and the usable horizon

For the common-factor process in Eq. (3), retaining every bth observation changes persistence from λ to $r = \lambda^b$. The integrated correlation term in Eq. (8) admits the closed form

$$\sum_{s=1}^{N-1}(N-s)r^s = \frac{r\{(N-1) - Nr + r^N\}}{(1-r)^2}. \quad (13)$$

For nonnegative persistence, increasing b suppresses the positive correlation term, but Eq. (7) decreases approximately as $1/b$ when the environment clock binds.

Consequently, aggressive thinning can make retained observations nearly independent and still increase terminal error.

The next section jointly prices noise and contraction over this affordable horizon.

IV. Lyapunov-Certified Joint Resource Control

A. Action-dependent one-block drift

The base Lyapunov function is the squared parameter error $V(e) = \|e\|^2$. Delay prevents its one-step drift from closing in e_k alone because the update also contains $e_{k-\tau_i}$. We therefore analyze the observable-independent sliding envelope

$$R_k = \max_{k-2D\le s\le k} \mathbb{E}V(e_s), \tag{14}$$

which is a Lyapunov–Razumikhin construction for the lifted history $(e_k, e_{k-1}, \dots, e_{k-2D})$.

Define the aggregate stationary moments

$$K_q = \lambda_{\max}\big(\mathbb{E}_{\pi_q}[\bar{H}_k^\top \bar{H}_k]\big), \quad \Omega_q = \mathbb{E}_{\pi_q}\|\bar{\xi}_k\|^2, \tag{15}$$

where $\bar{H}_k = q^{-1}\sum_i H_{i,k}$ and $\bar{\xi}_k = q^{-1}\sum_i \xi_{i,k}$. Let $\delta = C_q r_q^b$ and $\mu_\delta = \mu - 2L\delta$. For the delay root-mean-square $\tau_{\rm rms} = (q^{-1}\sum_i \tau_i^2)^{1/2}$, define

$$\begin{aligned} a_\delta(\eta) &= 1 - \eta\mu_\delta + \eta^2(2K_q + 4L^2\delta),\\ \beta_\delta(\eta) &= \frac{4\eta G^2\delta^2}{\mu_\delta} + \eta^2(2\Omega_q + 4G^2\delta),\\ h_\tau(\eta) &= 2\eta^4 L^4 \tau_{\rm rms}^2, \quad g_\tau(\eta) = 2\eta^4 L^2 G^2 \tau_{\rm rms}^2. \end{aligned} \tag{16}$$

For positive delay, set $\lambda_\star = \sqrt{h_\tau/a_\delta}$ and

$$\begin{aligned} c_{\rm aff} &= (1+\lambda_\star)a_\delta + (1+\lambda_\star^{-1})h_\tau,\\ d_{\rm aff} &= (1+\lambda_\star)\beta_\delta + (1+\lambda_\star^{-1})g_\tau. \end{aligned} \tag{17}$$

The zero-delay definitions are the continuous limits $c_{\rm aff} = a_\delta$ and $d_{\rm aff} = \beta_\delta$. These coefficients separate mean contraction from sampling noise, finite-mixing bias, and the fourth-order delay terms.

Theorem 1 (Affine delayed Markov Lyapunov bound)**.** *Suppose Assumption 1 holds, $\mu_\delta > 0$, $a_\delta(\eta) > 0$, and $c_{\rm aff}(a) < 1$. Let $m = 2D+1$ and $R_k = \max_{k-2D\le s\le k}\mathbb{E}\|e_s\|^2$. Then, for every integer $n \ge 0$,*

$$R_{nm} \le c_{\rm aff}(a)^n R_0 + \frac{d_{\rm aff}(a)}{1 - c_{\rm aff}(a)}. \tag{18}$$

Appendix A proves the bound: correlation enters (K_q, Ω_q), persistence enters δ, and delay changes contraction and forcing.

Corollary 1 (Finite-horizon return certificate)**.** *Under Theorem 1, let $n = \lfloor N_a(B)/(2D+1)\rfloor$ and let $\psi_\nu = \mathbb{E}_{s\sim\nu}\phi(s)$. Then*

$$\mathbb{E}\,|J_\nu(w_{N_a}) - J_\nu(w^\star)|^2 \le \|\psi_\nu\|^2\left[c_{\rm aff}^n R_0 + \frac{d_{\rm aff}}{1-c_{\rm aff}}\right]. \tag{19}$$

Appendix A-B handles incomplete terminal blocks and connects parameter risk to fixed-policy value-estimation error.

The same certificate also tracks a critic target moved by a policy learner. Let $w_r^\star$ be the projected fixed point during epoch r, lasting one replacement block $m = 2D+1$, and let $Z_r = \max_{rm-2D\le s\le rm}\mathbb{E}\|w_s - w_r^\star\|^2$.

Theorem 2 (Moving-policy critic tracking)**.** *Suppose every epoch satisfies Assumption 1, possibly with a different certified action a_r, and its coefficients obey $c_{\rm aff}(a_r) \le c < 1$ and $d_{\rm aff}(a_r) \le d$. Require the fixed-target one-step inequality $\mathbb{E}\|w_{k+1} - w_r^\star\|^2 \le c\max_{k-2D\le s\le k}\mathbb{E}\|w_s - w_r^\star\|^2 + d$ throughout epoch r, including its mixed-history boundary. This requirement holds for a consistently initialized epoch with no carried old-target updates; without that protocol it is an additional uniform-history condition. If the policy-induced target moves only between epochs and $\|w_{r+1}^\star - w_r^\star\| \le v$, then for every $\chi > 0$ satisfying $\bar{c} = (1+\chi)c < 1$,*

$$Z_n \le \bar{c}^n Z_0 + \frac{(1+\chi)d + (1+\chi^{-1})v^2}{1-\bar{c}}, \tag{20}$$

$$\mathbb{E}|\widehat{A}_w - A^\star|^2 \le (1+\gamma)^2\Phi^2 Z_n, \quad \|\phi(s)\| \le \Phi. \tag{21}$$

The bound exposes a moving-target phase: policy improvement increases v, while the resource action determines (c, d). Appendix A-C proves the positive-part recursion. Under the uniform-history condition, recomputing the joint score at actor-epoch boundaries controls the certified critic lag.

B. Joint action selection

For $n_a = \lfloor N_a(B)/m\rfloor$, the certificate score is

$$\mathcal{U}_j(a; B, D) = R_\star(a) + c_{\rm aff}(a)^{n_a}\,(R_0 - R_\star(a))_+, \tag{22}$$

where $R_\star(a) = d_{\rm aff}(a)/(1-c_{\rm aff}(a))$. The certified oracle for a known dependence instance is

$$a_j^\star(B, D) \in \arg\min_{a\in\mathcal{A}} \mathcal{U}_j(a; B, D). \tag{23}$$

For every pair (q, b), define the certified scalar domain

$$\begin{aligned} \mathcal{E}_{q,b} = \{\eta \in [\eta_{\min}, \eta_{\max}] : \mu_\delta \ge \mu_0 > 0,\\ a_\delta(\eta) \ge a_0 > 0,\ c_{\rm aff}(q, b, \eta) \le 1 - \kappa\}, \end{aligned} \tag{24}$$

The controller solves

$$\eta^\star_{q,b} \in \arg\min_{\eta\in\mathcal{E}_{q,b}} \mathcal{U}_j(q,b,\eta;B,D),$$
$$(q^\star,b^\star) \in \arg\min_{q,b} \mathcal{U}_j(q,b,\eta^\star_{q,b};B,D). \quad (25)$$

Here $\eta_{\min} > 0$, and μ_0, a_0, κ are declared positive certification margins. Pairs with empty scalar domains are omitted; at least one nonempty domain is required, otherwise the controller returns a declared feasible fallback or performs no update. The optimization defines global scalar minima; numerical candidates attain this oracle guarantee when their global accuracy is certified.

Proposition 2 (Existence and computation)**.** *If K_q, Ω_q, and the mixing certificates are finite and the declared certified domain is nonempty, then $\mathcal{U}_j$ is continuous on its compact scalar domains and attains a minimum. With $N_q = |\mathcal{Q}|$, $N_b = |\mathcal{B}|$, and L_η scalar evaluations per search, the certificate cost is $O(N_q N_b L_\eta)$ arithmetic after the moment table is cached. For rank-one temporal-difference samples, update aggregation costs $O(qd)$ arithmetic and $O(d)$ working memory per retained block; exact spectral moment calibration is a separate cost.*

Appendix A-D proves compactness and separates aggregation from spectral calibration.

C. Finite-horizon and one-step control

A purely myopic drift rule would minimize $c_{\mathrm{aff}}(a)R_k + d_{\mathrm{aff}}(a)$. Such a rule can prefer a large q or b even when its resource cost leaves too few future contractions. Eq. (22) instead composes the drift over the action-dependent horizon in Eq. (7).

V. Learning-Aware Dependence Adaptation

A. Adaptive information lower bound

When θ_j is unknown, the controller may choose a predictable sequence $A_k = (q_k, b_k, \eta_k)$ and stop at a budget-bounded stopping time τ. Rotating X_k into its normalized agent mean $Y_k = q_k^{-1/2}\mathbf{1}^\top X_k$ and orthogonal contrasts shows that only Y_k contributes to the likelihood ratio. Under hypothesis j, a scalar Kalman filter gives the predictive mean $m^-_{j,k}$ and variance $P^-_{j,k}$, with innovation variance $V_{j,k} = 1 + q_k P^-_{j,k}$.

Let $Z_k = (m^-_{0,k}, P^-_{0,k}, m^-_{1,k}, P^-_{1,k})$. The conditional directional information is

$$\mathcal{I}_{01}(Z_k,A_k) = \frac{1}{2}\Bigg[\log\frac{V_{1,k}}{V_{0,k}} - 1 + \frac{V_{0,k} + q_k(m^-_{0,k} - m^-_{1,k})^2}{V_{1,k}}\Bigg]. \quad (26)$$

The dependence of information on the resource action is already visible under a fixed probe. Let $T_n(r)$ be the $n \times n$ Toeplitz matrix with entries $[T_n(r)]_{uv} = r^{|u-v|}$, and let $\zeta_1, \dots, \zeta_n$ be its eigenvalues.

Proposition 3 (Exact fixed-probe information)**.** *For a fixed probe (q,b,n) with $r = \lambda^b$, the directional Kullback–Leibler (KL) divergence is*

$$\mathrm{KL}(P_0^{q,b,n} \| P_1^{q,b,n}) = \frac{1}{2}\sum_{\ell=1}^{n}\left[x_\ell - 1 - \log x_\ell\right], \quad (27)$$

where $x_\ell = (1+q\theta_0\zeta_\ell)/(1+q\theta_1\zeta_\ell)$. The Bhattacharyya exponent used by the upper rule is

$$I_B(q,b,n) = \frac{1}{2}\sum_{\ell=1}^{n}\log\frac{1+q(\theta_0+\theta_1)\zeta_\ell/2}{\sqrt{(1+q\theta_0\zeta_\ell)(1+q\theta_1\zeta_\ell)}}. \quad (28)$$

They follow by diagonalizing the common-mode covariance $I + q\theta_j T_n(r)$; the orthogonal spatial contrasts have identical laws under both hypotheses. Participation scales common-mode eigenvalues rather than creating independent temporal records.

Theorem 3 (Stopped adaptive information identity)**.** *If the action kernel is predictable and common to both hypotheses and τ is bounded by Eq.* (6)*, then*

$$\mathrm{KL}(P_0^\pi|\mathcal{F}_\tau \,\|\, P_1^\pi|\mathcal{F}_\tau) = \mathbb{E}_0^\pi \sum_{k=1}^{\tau}\mathcal{I}_{01}(Z_k,A_k). \quad (29)$$

The reverse identity holds after exchanging the hypotheses.

Appendix C proves cancellation of predictable action probabilities in the stopped likelihood. Consequently, any rule whose two directional decision errors are at most $\delta < 1/2$ must satisfy

$$\mathbb{E}_j^\pi \sum_{k\le\tau}\mathcal{I}_{j,1-j}(Z_k,A_k) \ge \mathrm{kl}(1-\delta,\delta). \quad (30)$$

Together with Eq. (6), this gives an occupation-measure lower bound that prices participation, spacing, stopping, and delay without reducing the adaptive Markov experiment to independent action counts.

For a measurable belief-state set G, define the stopped occupation measure

$$\nu_j(G,a) = \mathbb{E}_j^\pi \sum_{k\le\tau}\mathbf{1}\{Z_k \in G, A_k = a\}. \quad (31)$$

Let $\Delta_j(z,a)$ denote the certified one-step learning opportunity lost by using action a for identification instead of the known-instance learning action.

Proposition 4 (Adaptive opportunity lower bound)**.** *Every predictable, budget-feasible, δ-correct identification policy has expected opportunity cost at least*

$$\inf_{\nu\in\mathcal{M}_j}\int \Delta_j(z,a)\nu(dz,da), \tag{32}$$

where $\mathcal{M}_j$ contains the controlled Kalman-flow constraints, both resource constraints in Eq. (6)*, and the directional information constraint*

$$\int \mathcal{I}_{j,1-j}(z,a)\nu(dz,da)\geq \mathrm{kl}(1-\delta,\delta). \tag{33}$$

Appendix D proves the belief flow: an early (q,b) changes later predictive variances, so independent action counts cannot replace controlled occupations.

B. Learning-aware upper rule

A fixed probe design $d=(q_d,b_d,n_d)$ consumes $C_d^{\mathrm{msg}}=n_d(h+q_d)$ and $C_d^{\mathrm{env}}=n_d b_d$. Its length is chosen so the exact Bhattacharyya exponent is at least $\log(1/\delta)$, which bounds each directional error by δ. Write $B_d=(B_{\mathrm{msg}}-C_d^{\mathrm{msg}},B_{\mathrm{env}}-C_d^{\mathrm{env}})$. We use $B_d^D=B_d$ to mark the delayed learner; Eq. (7) charges its declared (ℓ,u) once.

The probe is disjoint from learning samples and pays $n_d(h+q_d)$ messages and $n_d b_d$ clock units. Learning starts from the declared parameter history, and its moment and mixing certificates must hold uniformly conditional on the probe history. All selectable actions, including a wrong-instance commitment, require valid certificates under either true instance.

For each probe d, freeze selected actions $\widetilde{a}_j$ before observing its data and set $\overline{R}_j^{\mathrm{sel}}=\overline{R}_j(\widetilde{a}_j;B_d^D,D)$. Selections may use scalar candidates or a shielded central score; admission uses the upper certificates of the actual frozen selections. With $\overline{R}_j^{\mathrm{all}}$ the fallback certificate, define

$$\begin{aligned}
C_j^{\mathrm{probe}}(d)&=\overline{R}_j^{\mathrm{all}}(B_d,0)-\overline{R}_j^{\mathrm{all}}(B,0),\\
C_j^D(d)&=\overline{R}_j^{\mathrm{all}}(B_d^D,D)-\overline{R}_j^{\mathrm{all}}(B_d,0)\\
&\quad-\left[\overline{R}_j^{\mathrm{all}}(B,D)-\overline{R}_j^{\mathrm{all}}(B,0)\right],\\
G_j(d)&=\overline{R}_j^{\mathrm{all}}(B_d^D,D)-\overline{R}_j^{\mathrm{sel}},\\
W_j(d)&=\max_{v\neq j}\left[\overline{R}_j(\widetilde{a}_v;B_d^D,D)-\overline{R}_j^{\mathrm{sel}}\right]_+.
\end{aligned} \tag{34}$$

Thus $C_j^{\mathrm{probe}}+C_j^D=\overline{R}_j^{\mathrm{all}}(B_d^D,D)-\overline{R}_j^{\mathrm{all}}(B,D)$ exactly. The signed C_j^D compares delay penalties against the same fallback; the auxiliary zero-delay certificate suppresses (D,u,ℓ) together. The low-instance safety slack is

$$\epsilon_{\mathrm{safe}}(d)=\left[C_0^{\mathrm{probe}}(d)+C_0^D(d)-G_0(d)+\delta W_0(d)\right]_+. \tag{35}$$

The learning-aware controller probes only when

$$\begin{aligned}
C_1^{\mathrm{probe}}(d)+C_1^D(d)+\delta W_1(d)&<G_1(d),\\
\epsilon_{\mathrm{safe}}(d)&\leq\bar{\epsilon}.
\end{aligned} \tag{36}$$

Otherwise it executes the all-agent fallback without spending a probe. After an admitted probe, it commits to $\widetilde{a}_{\widehat{j}}$.

Any publicly specified certified fallback can replace the all-agent reference in Eq. (34).

Theorem 4 (Main finite-budget learning-value guarantee)**.** *Suppose Assumption 1 holds for both instances, the probe is feasible under Eq.* (6)*, and its directional errors are bounded by δ. Require each post-probe action's certificate to hold conditional on the probe history, from the declared learning initialization with a common bound R_0. Every design admitted by Eq.* (36) *satisfies*

$$\mathbb{E}_j\|e_{\mathrm{LA}}\|^2\leq\overline{R}_j^{\mathrm{sel}}+\delta W_j(d), \tag{37}$$

has a high-instance risk upper bound strictly below the full-budget all-agent certificate, and has low-instance risk at most $\overline{R}_0^{\mathrm{all}}(B,D)+\bar{\epsilon}$. If no design is feasible or admitted, the controller returns the all-agent action and incurs no probing cost.

Appendix E proves the conditional risk decomposition.

C. Same-stream risk transfer

Disjoint probe and learning observations can remain dependent through the common state at the probe's terminal time T. For the Gaussian model in Eq. (3), a fixed probe gives $C_T\mid\mathcal{H}_d\sim\mathcal{N}(m_j,P_j)$, with deterministic P_j and $\mathbb{E}_j m_j^2=s_j^2:=\theta_j-P_j$. For $\bar{X}_{q,t}=q^{-1}\sum_{i=1}^q X_{i,t}$, freeze two downstream linear programs with deterministic coefficients before probing:

$$Z_a=d_a+\sum_{t=1}^{N_a}\omega_{a,t}\bar{X}_{q_a,T+b_a t},\quad k_a=\sum_{t=1}^{N_a}\omega_{a,t}\lambda^{b_a t}. \tag{38}$$

Write $J_{j,a}=\mathbb{E}_j Z_a^2$ for a deterministic commitment to a on the stationary stream. For the correct program a_c and wrong program a_w, define

$$\begin{aligned}
\Delta J_j&=J_{j,a_w}-J_{j,a_c},\\
\Gamma_j^2&=4(d_{a_w}k_{a_w}-d_{a_c}k_{a_c})^2 s_j^2\\
&\quad+2(k_{a_w}^2-k_{a_c}^2)^2 s_j^4.
\end{aligned} \tag{39}$$

Theorem 5 (Same-stream actual-risk enclosure)**.** *For a fixed feasible probe with directional decision error at most δ, followed by either frozen program in Eq.* (38) *on the continuing stream,*

$$\begin{aligned}
\mathbb{E}_j Z_{\widehat{a}}^2&\geq\left[J_{j,a_c}-\delta[-\Delta J_j]_+-\sqrt{\delta}\Gamma_j\right]_+,\\
\mathbb{E}_j Z_{\widehat{a}}^2&\leq J_{j,a_c}+\delta[\Delta J_j]_+ +\sqrt{\delta}\Gamma_j.
\end{aligned} \tag{40}$$

Allow distinct valid directional bounds δ_j in Eq. (40) and define

$$U_j(d) = J_{j,a_c(d)} + \delta_j[\Delta J_j(d)]_+ + \sqrt{\delta_j}\Gamma_j(d),$$
$$F_j = J_{j,\mathrm{all}}(B), \qquad U_1(d) < F_1, \quad U_0(d) \le F_0 + \bar{\epsilon}. \tag{41}$$

All post-probe horizons in J use the remaining budgets; F_j spends no probe cost. Select a feasible passing design deterministically before observing data, or return the full-budget fallback. Theorem 5 then gives actual high-instance improvement and the low-instance allowance in Eq. (41), without a uniform conditional Gaussian certificate. The supplementary material supplies the proof, exact learner weights, an executable gate, and its saved-result reconstruction.

D. Finite-budget phase theorem

Let budgets grow on a public ray $(B_{\mathrm{msg}}(s), B_{\mathrm{env}}(s)) = (\lfloor s\beta_m \rfloor, \lfloor s\beta_e \rfloor)$. Consider a compact class with $0 < \theta_- \le \theta_j \le \theta_+$, $|\theta_1 - \theta_0| \ge \Delta_{\min} > 0$, $|\lambda| \le 1 - \gamma$, bounded delay, finite $\mathcal{Q}, \mathcal{B}$, and a nonempty compact certified step domain. Require uniformly: (a) a fixed probe has $I_B(q, b, n) \ge ni_- > 0$; (b) $|\overline{R}_j(a; s) - K_j(a)/s| \le M/s^2$, and removing cost v changes each certificate by at most $L(v + 1)/s^2$ for $s \ge s_0(v + 1)$; (c) the selected actions satisfy $K_1(\mathrm{all}) - K_1(\widetilde{a}_1) \ge g_{\min} > 0$ and $K_0(\widetilde{a}_0) \le K_0(\mathrm{all})$; and (d) $W_j(d; s) \le w_+/s$, with $\delta_0 w_+ \le g_{\min}/2$. The Gaussian running mean with independently initialized learning data satisfies the risk expansion and budget-shift conditions (Appendix F). This shrinking-risk class is distinct from the fixed positive-step affine recursion, whose certificate has a nonzero noise floor. Here v is the probe charge in budget-ray units, including bounded delay and rounding costs. Set $B_{\mathrm{oracle}} = 4M/g_{\min}$ and $B_\epsilon = (M + L + \delta_0 w_+)/\bar{\epsilon}$ for $\bar{\epsilon} > 0$. Let B_N be the smallest scale satisfying the two directional information constraints, and B_S the infimum of scales above which an admitted design exists at every larger scale.

Theorem 6 (Necessary–sufficient threshold sandwich)**.** *For every fixed admissible safety target and $0 < \delta \le \delta_0 < 1/2$, there are class constants $C_{\mathcal{K}}, C'_{\mathcal{K}} < \infty$ such that*

$$B_N \le B_S \le C_{\mathcal{K}} B_N + C'_{\mathcal{K}}(B_{\mathrm{oracle}} + B_\epsilon + 1). \tag{42}$$

Below B_N, δ-correct identification is impossible, while above B_S the learning-aware controller achieves the guarantees of Theorem 4.

Appendix F derives the expected-information and scale bounds, separating identification feasibility from downstream learning value. For a stable averaged affine learner on the same stream, $\sqrt{\delta}\Gamma_j = O(\sqrt{\delta}/s^2)$; the supplementary derivation extends the shrinking-risk interface and scale argument to the corrected upper rule.

Input: budgets B, lag profile, terminal charges (ℓ, u), action sets, step interval, allowance $\bar{\epsilon}$
for each dependence instance j and pair (q, b) **do**
  form δ, K_q, Ω_q, and the certified set $\mathcal{E}_{q,b}$
  construct scalar candidates and their valid upper certificates
end for
for each feasible prespecified probe d **do**
  charge its message, environment, and delay costs
  freeze shielded selections $\widetilde{a}_j$ and upper scores for the remaining budget
  evaluate C_j^{probe}, C_j^D, G_j, W_j, and ϵ_{safe}
end for
if some probe satisfies Eq. (36) **then**
  choose the admitted probe with smallest certified post-probe risk
  observe the charged probe, run the likelihood test, and commit to $\widetilde{a}_{\widehat{j}}$
else
  execute the certified fallback without probing
end if
Output: value parameter and complete resource ledger

Fig. 1. Learning-aware Lyapunov resource control.

VI. Implementation and Stochastic-Delay Interpretation

A. End-to-end controller

Algorithm 1 fixes the catalogue and confidence level before data. Cached system specifications or disjoint calibration provide moment/mixing certificates; the likelihood probe selects between prespecified instances.

B. Predictable confidence interfaces

Predictable upper bounds on moments and mixing turn calibration estimates into risk certificates. For a known finite augmented Markov model, the supplementary construction computes these quantities from its kernel and stationary law, including a worst-state total-variation bound at the actual TD-pair gap. For an unknown model, the following confidence interface still requires simultaneous coverage; point estimates alone do not provide it. For a calibration block ending before action selection, let $\widehat{K}_q$, $\widehat{\Omega}_q$, and $\widehat{r}_q$ be estimators and

let u_K, u_Ω, u_r be simultaneous error radii. The controller uses

$$K_q^+ = \widehat{K}_q + u_K, \quad \Omega_q^+ = \widehat{\Omega}_q + u_\Omega, \\ r_q^+ = \min\{1, \widehat{r}_q + u_r\}. \tag{43}$$

For each valid calibration realization, the upper quantities preserve the drift inequalities conditional on that calibration history. An action is excluded if $r_q^+ = 1$, or if the resulting μ_δ or step domain is invalid.

The upper values define a feasibility shield and risk envelope; a predictable central score may rank shield-passing actions. Write $a_a = a_\delta(\eta)$, $h_a = h_\tau(\eta)$, $c_a = c_{\mathrm{aff}}(a)$, $d_a = d_{\mathrm{aff}}(a)$, and $n = n_a$.

Corollary 2 (Robust certificate and selection sensitivity)**.** *Suppose $K_q^+ \geq K_q$, $\Omega_q^+ \geq \Omega_q$, and $r_q^+ \geq r_q$ jointly, and form c_a^+, d_a^+ from the upper values using $\lambda_a^+ = \sqrt{h_a/a_a^+}$ and the zero-delay limit. Every action satisfying $\mu_{\delta^+} > 0$ and $c_a^+ < 1$ obeys $\mathbb{E}\|e_{k+1}\|^2 \leq c_a^+ R_k + d_a^+$ and the replacement-block recurrence $(R_{k+2D+1} - R_\star^+)_+ \leq c_a^+ (R_k - R_\star^+)_+$, where $R_\star^+ = d_a^+/(1 - c_a^+)$. Moreover, if $c_a, c_a^+ \leq \bar{c} < 1$ and $d_a, d_a^+ \leq \bar{d}$, then*

$$|\mathcal{U}_a^+ - \mathcal{U}_a| \leq \left(nR_0 + \frac{\bar{d}}{(1-\bar{c})^2} \right) \Delta c_a \\ + \frac{\Delta d_a}{1 - \bar{c}} =: \varepsilon_a. \tag{44}$$

Consequently, minimizing the upper score incurs at most $2 \max_a \varepsilon_a$ certified risk beyond the exact-certificate oracle.

Here $\Delta c_a = |c_a^+ - c_a|$ and $\Delta d_a = |d_a^+ - d_a|$ admit the explicit moment- and mixing-slack bounds in the supplementary material. Valid upper certificates control risk, while their tightness controls selection loss continuously.

Spectral, regeneration, or externally supplied mixing certificates must hold simultaneously at the conditioning scope of the drift bound. An unconditional squared-error bound also requires control of loss on the calibration coverage-failure event.

The supplementary material gives the associated stochastic delay differential equation and its contraction–forcing interpretation. The algorithm uses the discrete theorem with finite steps, integer delays, and exact rounding.

VII. Simulations

A. Protocol and evaluation questions

The simulations test three questions: how dependence changes the resource action, whether finite-horizon control improves estimation, and whether participation selection transfers to cooperative policy learning. An additional direct validation tests the actual-risk gate separately from the saved-result reanalysis. The affine action/convergence studies use scalarized cost $h + q + b$ per update with $(\ell, u) = (0, 0)$; their D controls stale parameter indices. EXP-016B uses separate budgets, $(\ell, u) = (0, D)$, and pays every scheduled block, including the final D withheld updates. Theorem 5 covers its consecutive Gaussian probe/learning blocks and averaged first-in, first-out learner through their exact linear weights.

Studies pair common random numbers, charge all messages and clock units, retain prespecified cells, and use same-seed reproductions or disjoint confirmation seeds. The Markov temporal-difference task has seven states on a ring, a bounded sinusoidal reward, four stationary-distribution-orthonormal features, and an exact projected fixed point. Cross-agent dependence is induced by shared and private Markov sources while preserving every agent's marginal transition law. The policy-learning studies use MAPPO with parameter-shared actors and a centralized critic [37]. They cover PettingZoo's multi-agent particle environment `simple_spread_v2` [38] and the multi-agent MuJoCo (MaMuJoCo) `HalfCheetah-v2/2x3` benchmark [39].

Parameter risk is $\|w - w^\star\|^2$ normalized by its value before learning. Return-estimation risk is $|V_w(s_0) - V_{w^\star}(s_0)|^2$ under the specified initial state and is normalized in the same way. Convergence AUC uses charged resource fraction, including probe costs. Bootstrap comparisons resample paired seeds and report percentile intervals for the ratio of geometric-mean risks.

B. Correlation-limited participation

The participation study varies $q \in \{1, 2, 4, 8, 16, 32\}$, six cross-agent correlation levels, three delays, three message-equivalent budgets, and thirteen step sizes over 32 paired seeds. At $q = 32$, median effective participation is 30.996 for independent trajectories and 1.111 at correlation 0.9. At the largest evaluated budget and delay eight, the resource-optimal participation moves from $q = 16$ under independence to $q = 1$ under high sharing. Using the endpoint action selected for the opposite correlation regime increases error by factors of approximately 4.29 and 3.13, respectively. Equal charged endpoint budgets isolate the value of dependence-matched participation.

C. Finite-time certificate and joint actions

The joint-action study evaluates twelve $(\text{persistence}, \rho, D)$ scenarios with 32 new paired seeds and 1,152 policy runs. The joint controller searches a stability-screened catalogue of $q \in \{1, 2, 4, 8, 16, 32\}$,

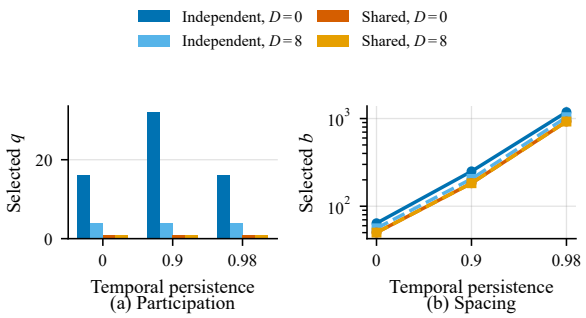


Fig. 2. Joint actions selected by the finite-time Lyapunov certificate. The left panel reports participation and the right panel reports Markov spacing; persistence values occupy categorical positions.

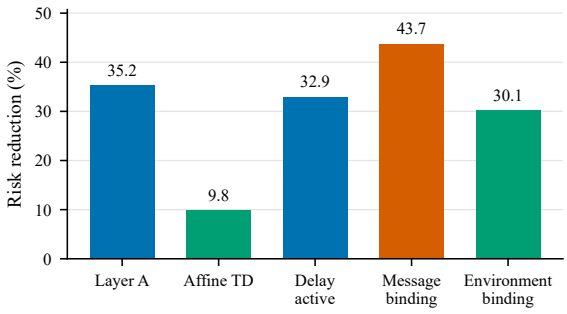


Fig. 3. Relative risk reductions of the learning-aware rule over information-only probing. All percentages use information-only risk as the denominator.

charged spacings, and scalar steps. All selected actions satisfy $0 < c_{\text{aff}} < 1$ and the declared budget.

The finite-time bound beats the no-update risk in all twelve scenarios (12/12). Every one-sided 99 percent bootstrap upper mean lies below its corresponding bound, with a maximum empirical-upper-bound to theorem-bound ratio of 0.305. The median theorem-bound to empirical-mean ratio is 20.77 and the maximum is 228.98. The resulting actions below show how the certificate responds to correlation, delay, and persistence despite this slack.

Fig. 2 shows mean participation 12.67 for independent sources and $q = 1$ in every high-sharing scenario. Delay reduces the selected independent-source participation to $q = 4$, while raising temporal persistence from zero to 0.98 increases the median paid spacing by a factor of 18.49.

D. Learning-value adaptation

The dependence-adaptation study uses 96 finite-threshold scenario families, two model layers, eight policies, and 192 independent evaluation seeds. The primary estimand is the paired risk difference between probing at B_{id} and applying the learning-value gate in the separation phase.

Relative to information-only probing, the learning-aware controller reduces Layer-A risk by 35.24 percent and affine delayed temporal-difference risk by 9.79 percent. Each reduction divides the paired risk improvement by the information-only risk. The simultaneous one-sided lower bounds on the absolute paired improvements are 0.1612 and 0.0577, respectively. Directional practical improvement occurs in 77 of 96 scenario families. All 96 prespecified design-level safety checks satisfy $S_{\text{mean}} \leq \epsilon_{\text{safe}}$, and every trajectory obeys both resource budgets.

An analytical reanalysis applies Eq. (40) to all 104 saved scenario families, including eight search-censored families, and all eight policies without changing their decisions. The saved probes' nominal 0.025 target bounds equal-prior average classification error; we use their exact Gaussian affinities, 0.03523–0.04975, as valid directional-error upper bounds in Eq. (40). On the original practical separation subset, the mean population improvement over information-only probing is enclosed by $[0.1607, 0.1952]$ in Layer A and $[0.0562, 0.0773]$ in Layer B; the observed means are 0.1767 and 0.0726. The bounds include selection dependence and need no independent learning reset. They also resolve individual adverse comparisons: 101/446 Layer-A and 33/222 Layer-B cells in that subset have negative improvement upper bounds. Across the entire Layer-B separation region, the mean enclosure is $[-0.0049, 0.0252]$, so the positive aggregate guarantee is specific to the original practical subset, not every intermediate budget or regime. Both policies are identical above the finite value thresholds and below identification.

Fig. 3 gives reductions of 32.94 percent with delay, 43.72 percent when messages bind, and 30.13 percent when transitions bind: probing is costly when it consumes the remaining learner's limiting resource.

E. Direct validation of the actual-risk gate

A separate validation executes the gate based on Theorem 5: 16 Gaussian families, two learners, two regimes, four budget scales, and 128 new paired seeds. The corrected gate, no-carryover ablation, information-only probe, all-agent fallback, fixed $(q, b) = (2, 1)$, and evaluation oracle give 196,608 trajectories, all semantically replayed. The supplement reports the full protocol, all 16 macro comparisons, and all-policy costs.

The exact-affinity probe meets directional bound 0.025; 113/128 designs admit probing. Fig. 4 averages

all families. All eight high-regime improvement intervals over fallback are positive, but low-regime running-mean scale 32 gives -0.00229 with descriptive paired-bootstrap 95 percent interval $[-0.00323, -0.00136]$. There are 23/256 adverse cell means; the low-instance allowance is 0.1, not zero harm.

Corrected and no-carryover decisions and risks coincide on all 32,768 paired rows, leaving the correction's incremental empirical benefit unresolved. Fixed $(2, 1)$ has lower pooled risk and environment cost but uses more messages: the gate does not dominate every control. Known-model population enclosures are neither confidence limits for sample means nor unknown-kernel calibration guarantees.

F. Convergence and return-estimation curves

The convergence study tests the complete joint controller on the seven-state policy-evaluation problem over a budget of 128,000 resource units. The prespecified grid crosses persistence $\{0, 0.9, 0.98\}$, correlation $\{0, 0.9\}$, and delay $\{0, 8\}$, producing twelve cells and 41 charged-resource checkpoints per trajectory. The fixed policies use $q \in \{1, 4, 16, 32\}$; within every cell, each fixed q receives its own certified spacing and step. This comparison isolates the value of choosing participation while allowing every policy to adapt its spacing and step.

Sixteen development seeds select fixed $q = 4$; the locked comparison uses 64 disjoint confirmation seeds and 157,440 finite checkpoint rows.

Relative to fixed $q = 4$, the joint certificate has parameter-error AUC ratio 0.9009 with paired-bootstrap 95 percent interval $[0.8914, 0.9102]$. Its discounted-return-estimation AUC ratio is 0.8868 with interval $[0.8678, 0.9072]$. Terminal parameter and return-estimation errors decrease by 26.48 and 21.67 percent, respectively. Both AUC metrics improve in nine of twelve cells and tie in the remaining three; no cell is worse.

Fig. 5 shows the persistence-0.9, zero-delay slice: broad participation accelerates independent-source learning, whereas low participation avoids the shared-noise floor.

G. Transfer across cooperative policy-learning environments

Held-out, fully charged MAPPO studies select dependence-matched participation in all 32 controller runs. Against the strongest single fixed action, $q = 8$, normalized AUC improves by 2.319 percent in particles and the paired equal-regime mixture by 8.341 percent in locomotion. The supplement retains both complete protocols, fixed-participation comparisons, paired statistics, and unsmoothed return curves; these are not comparisons with general multi-agent optimizers.

H. Ablations, complexity, and reproducibility

The confidence-interface study uses 64 disjoint confirmation seeds and 157,440 checkpoint rows. The moderate stress inflates K_q and Ω_q by 10 percent and weakens the certified mixing log-rate by 0.05; the strong stress uses 25 percent and 0.10. Both shields retain the nominal action in all twelve cells, all 24 stress-by-cell one-sided 99 percent upper means remain below the robust certificate, and neither shield changes empirical terminal risk.

The same study also isolates the finite-horizon objective. Against one-step myopic drift, terminal parameter risk falls by 12.20 percent; against a correlation-only participation rule, it falls by 64.22 percent. The respective ratios and paired-bootstrap 95 percent intervals are 0.878 $[0.836, 0.923]$ and 0.358 $[0.307, 0.412]$, both strictly below one.

Likelihood updates are scalar, and cached certificate search has the cost in Proposition 2, with spectral calibration charged separately.

Controlled statistics/curves reproduce byte for byte; robustness uses eight development and 64 disjoint confirmation seeds. Each policy-learning study has 80 finite, exactly budgeted runs spanning both regimes and all policies; all 160 runs reproduce aggregate curves byte for byte.

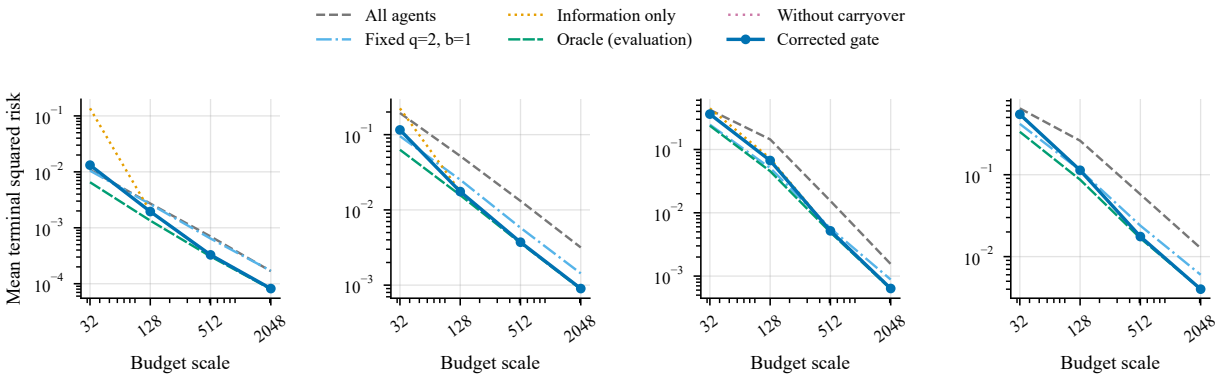
These ablations quantify the terminal parameter-risk gain from the finite-horizon objective; the joint-action study isolates the response to correlation, spacing, and delay.

VIII. Conclusion

Finite-budget Lyapunov control balances contraction, correlated noise, and the affordable learning horizon when selecting participation, spacing, and step size. The learning-value gate charges identification against its certified downstream benefit. The analysis and resource-matched studies link dependence-aware sampling to lower estimation risk and improved cooperative returns. Direct fixed-model validation also exposes adverse low-regime comparisons and an unchanged no-carryover ablation, delimiting the empirical evidence for the actual-risk correction.

Appendix A
Proof of the Affine Delayed Markov Bound

Fix a stationary action $a = (q, b, \eta)$ and condition on the history immediately before the retained joint observation. All expectations below include the Markov observations; the delay profile is deterministic as spec-



(a) Running mean, low (b) Running mean, high (c) Delayed affine, low (d) Delayed affine, high

Fig. 4. Direct validation on new seeds: terminal squared risk averaged over all 16 families and 128 seeds per family, at each learner, regime, and budget scale. All six policies are shown; the corrected and no-carryover curves coincide exactly. Lines connect distinct budget experiments, not within-run learning checkpoints.

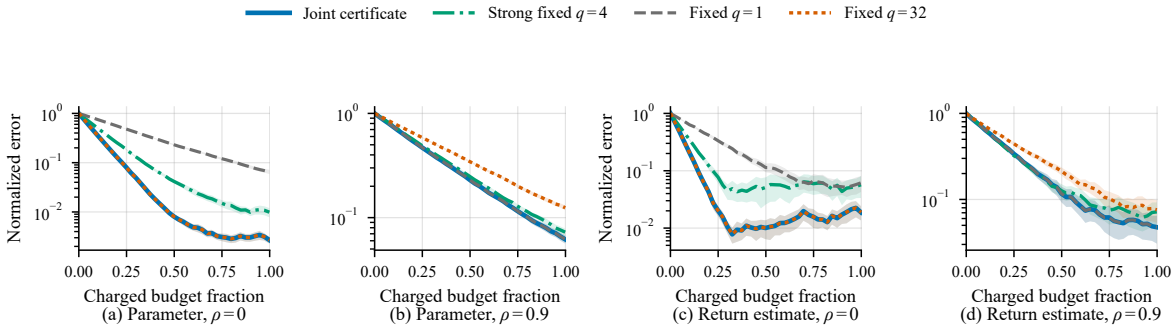


Fig. 5. Held-out resource-indexed convergence for persistence 0.9 and zero delay (64 confirmation seeds; bands are 95 percent confidence intervals). The first two panels show parameter risk and the last two return-estimation risk, compared with the development-selected fixed $q = 4$.

ified in Assumption 1. Write $\bar{H}_k = q^{-1}\sum_i H_{i,k}$, $\bar{\xi}_k = q^{-1}\sum_i \xi_{i,k}$, and

$$v_k = e_k - \eta(\bar{H}_k e_k - \bar{\xi}_k), \quad r_k = \frac{1}{q}\sum_i H_{i,k}(e_{k-\tau_i} - e_k). \tag{45}$$

Then Eq. (4) is $e_{k+1} = v_k - \eta r_k$.

Total-variation duality and stationary centering give

$$\left\|\mathbb{E}[\bar{\xi}_k \mid \mathcal{F}_k]\right\| \le 2G\delta. \tag{46}$$

Moreover, stationarity and the bounded integrand imply

$$\mathbb{E}[\|\bar{H}_k e - \bar{\xi}_k\|^2 \mid \mathcal{F}_k] \le (2K_q + 4L^2\delta)\|e\|^2 + 2\Omega_q + 4G^2\delta. \tag{47}$$

Combining Eq. (46) with the strong monotonicity of A and applying Young's inequality with parameter μ_δ yields

$$\mathbb{E}\|v_k\|^2 \le a_\delta(\eta)R_k + \beta_\delta(\eta). \tag{48}$$

The affine telescoping identity retains the innovation:

$$e_{k-\tau_i} - e_k = \eta \sum_{s=k-\tau_i}^{k-1} \left[\frac{1}{q}\sum_j H_{j,s}e_{s-\tau_j} - \bar{\xi}_s\right]. \tag{49}$$

Jensen's inequality and the almost-sure bounds in Assumption 1 give

$$\mathbb{E}\|r_k\|^2 \le 2\eta^2 L^4 \tau_{\mathrm{rms}}^2 R_k + 2\eta^2 L^2 G^2 \tau_{\mathrm{rms}}^2. \tag{50}$$

For any $\lambda > 0$,

$$\|v_k - \eta r_k\|^2 \le (1+\lambda)\|v_k\|^2 + (1+\lambda^{-1})\eta^2\|r_k\|^2. \tag{51}$$

Substituting Eq. (48) and Eq. (50) gives $\mathbb{E}\|e_{k+1}\|^2 \le c_\lambda R_k + d_\lambda$. The choice $\lambda = \sqrt{h_\tau/a_\delta}$ minimizes the contraction coefficient and produces Eq. (17). For zero delay, $r_k = 0$ and the continuous limiting definitions follow directly.

Let $R_\star = d_{\mathrm{aff}}/(1-c_{\mathrm{aff}})$. If $R_k \ge R_\star$, every new value entering the sliding envelope is at most $c_{\mathrm{aff}}R_k + d_{\mathrm{aff}} \le$

R_k. If $R_k < R_\star$, the same one-step bound keeps every new value below $R_\star$. Thus, in both cases, each new value is at most $R_\star + c_{\mathrm{aff}}(R_k - R_\star)_+$. After $2D+1$ updates the entire old window is replaced, giving $(R_{k+2D+1} - R_\star)_+ \le c_{\mathrm{aff}}(R_k - R_\star)_+$. Iteration gives $R_{nm} \le R_\star + c_{\mathrm{aff}}^n(R_0 - R_\star)_+ \le c_{\mathrm{aff}}^n R_0 + R_\star$, proving Theorem 1.

A. Proof of Corollary 2

The shared-Young-parameter comparison and explicit moment-slack bounds are given in the supplementary material.

B. Return transfer and arbitrary terminal indices

Let $n = \lfloor N_a/(2D+1) \rfloor$. The envelope argument keeps every later incomplete-block iterate below $\max\{R_{n(2D+1)}, R_\star\}$, which is the truncated-transient form in Eq. (22). Since $J_\nu(w) - J_\nu(w^\star) = \psi_\nu^\top e$ for $\psi_\nu = \mathbb{E}_{s\sim\nu}\phi(s)$, Cauchy–Schwarz and the terminal envelope prove Corollary 1.

C. Proof of Theorem 2

The complete positive-part tracking and advantage-transfer proof is retained in the supplementary material.

D. Existence and complexity of the mixed controller

For fixed (q, b), every coefficient and Eq. (22) is continuous on the declared positive-step domain. The nonstrict certification margins make that domain closed and bounded, so the extreme-value theorem applies whenever it is nonempty. Finite enumeration across nonempty pairs gives a global minimizer. A numerical implementation attains this oracle minimum when its scalar solver has certified global accuracy. The $N_q N_b$ scalar searches cost $O(N_q N_b L_\eta)$ evaluations. For rank-one $H_{i,k}$, feature inner products avoid dense matrices in update aggregation, which costs $O(qd)$ arithmetic and $O(d)$ memory. Exact spectral moment calibration is charged separately from rank-one update aggregation.

Appendix B
Correlation-Limited Minimax Risk

For one round of the Gaussian location subclass, the agent average has variance $\sigma_c^2 + \sigma_e^2/q$. The T round averages are independent and Gaussian with known variance, so their sample mean is minimax for squared loss over the unrestricted location family and has risk $T^{-1}(\sigma_c^2 + \sigma_e^2/q)$. Dividing the single-agent risk by this value gives Eq. (10). Since $1 + (q-1)\rho \ge q\rho$ for $\rho > 0$, the speedup is at most ρ^{-1}.

Appendix C
Proof of the Stopped Adaptive Information Identity

Condition on the pre-action history and realized action A_k. An orthogonal rotation maps X_k to $Y_k = q_k^{-1/2}\mathbf{1}^\top X_k$ and hypothesis-invariant standard-normal contrasts. Because the predictable action kernels cancel, the stopped log likelihood is the sum of scalar Kalman innovation ratios, where $Y_k \sim \mathcal{N}(\sqrt{q_k}\, m_{j,k}^-, V_{j,k})$. The conditional Gaussian divergence and the bounded-stopping chain rule give Eq. (26) and Eq. (29); exchanging hypotheses gives the reverse identity.

For a decision $\widehat{J}$, set $p_v = \mathbb{P}_v\{\widehat{J} = j\}$. Data processing gives

$$\mathrm{KL}(P_j^\pi|\mathcal{F}_\tau \,\|\, P_{1-j}^\pi|\mathcal{F}_\tau) \ge \mathrm{kl}(p_j, p_{1-j}). \tag{52}$$

If both directional errors are at most δ, monotonicity of binary relative entropy yields Eq. (30).

Appendix D
Occupation-Measure Opportunity Lower Bound

The supplementary material retains the complete stopped-flow proof of Proposition 4, including the occupation measure, information constraints and exact opportunity-loss identity.

Appendix E
Proof of the Main Learning-Value Guarantee

Let $\mathcal{H}_d$ be the complete probe history. The declared conditional certificate gives $\mathbb{E}_j[\|e_{\mathrm{LA}}\|^2 \mid \mathcal{H}_d] \le \overline{R}_j(\widetilde{a}_{\widehat{J}}; B_d^D, D)$ for either selected action. The right side is at most $\overline{R}_j^{\mathrm{sel}} + \mathbf{1}\{\widehat{J} \ne j\}W_j(d)$. Taking expectation and using the directional error bound proves Eq. (37).

Subtracting the full-budget all-agent certificate and using Eq. (34) gives

$$\mathbb{E}_1\|e_{\mathrm{LA}}\|^2 - \overline{R}_1^{\mathrm{all}}(B, D) \le C_1^{\mathrm{probe}} + C_1^D - G_1 + \delta W_1 < 0. \tag{53}$$

The same decomposition on instance zero is bounded above by $\epsilon_{\mathrm{safe}}(d) \le \bar{\epsilon}$. The fallback statement follows directly from the strict admission rule.

Appendix F
Proof of the Threshold Sandwich

The supplementary material gives the complete expected-information and scale calculation. Its lower bound uses uniform second moments of both Gaussian filters, not a pointwise bound on their conditional means. Combining that bound with Eq. (30) gives $B_N \ge c_N\,\mathrm{kl}(1-\delta, \delta)$. A fixed probe needs $n_\delta = O(\log(1/\delta)) = O(B_N + 1)$ observations. The risk expansion makes its high-instance benefit order s^{-1} and its lost-learning cost

order $(n_\delta + 1)s^{-2}$. The assumed leading gap dominates the wrong-decision term; low-instance safety follows above the stated allowance scale. Taking the maximum of these sufficient scales proves Eq. (42).

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